Almost Intelligent

Ever wonder how the humble washing machine got so smart? And what's this mysterious "Fuzzy Logic" got to do with it?

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Back in the good old days, you'd stare at your dirty laundry for a while, think, "Hmm... an hour for this lot," pop it into the old machine and twist the dial to the one-hour mark. The washing machine, like all the dumb machines of those times, would go about its business, little caring for how dirty the clothes are or how much water it's supposed to use. Ah, simpler times...

Today, your washing machine takes one look at your laundry, tut-tuts inwardly, and then tells you how much time it'll take to do its work. As it does so, it'll also make sure that not a drop of water is wasted, its temperature is just enough not to ruin your delicates without compromising on cleaning power. Short on detergent? No worries—the machine makes amends for that too. Regular super-*dhobi*, this.

And it's not just the washing machines, either—refrigerators, air conditioners and a whole assortment of household devices are getting smarter thanks to the miracle of fuzzy logic (no, they're not smart enough to come after you in your sleep, so stop shaking)—though you're more likely to have heard the term in a washing machine commercial.

Thinking Different

In the peak of summer, when you exclaim, "Boy, it's a hot day!", other humans have no trouble understanding you. Of course, dwellers of the equatorial region may not agree, but they'll still appreciate the sentiment regardless. A machine—a PC, for instance—won't have a clue, though. How do you define "hot"? Let's say you've programmed your PC to accept 30° Celsius as "hot." But machines only understand binary talk—yes or no, this or that, hot or cold. You can't expect them to have any concept of "maybe" or "somewhat hot." So to your PC, even 29.999° Celsius doesn't qualify as "hot". Silly, yes?

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